The Geography of Fear in Nigeria

A State-Level Secondary-Data Analysis with a Kidnapping Framing
Results report • 9 November 2026 • 37 states (36 + FCT)

This report compiles and analyses secondary data for a nationwide study of the **geography of fear** in Nigeria, framed around kidnapping and abduction. It overlays three layers: **objective violence/risk** (ACLED, 2020–2025), **perceived fear** (Afrobarometer Round 9, 2022), and **poverty/vulnerability** (OPHI MPI, MICS 2021), with population from NBS/NPC. The analytical contribution lies in the **mismatch** between where harm occurs and where fear is felt.

Scope & limitations.

Objective risk and poverty are measured at **state** level. Perceived fear is representative only at **North/South** level, so each state carries its regional fear value. The kidnapping measure is an abduction-*inclusive* proxy (ACLED civilian targeting), not a victim count. State-level fear and true kidnapping counts require Afrobarometer microdata and an ACLED abduction export respectively.

1. Violence and poverty across states

Bivariate OLS regressions (n = 37) test whether poverty predicts lethal violence.

Outcome (deaths per 100k, 2020–25)	slope	r	r^2	p
All political-violence deaths vs poverty	0.75	+0.37	0.14	0.025
Civilian-targeting deaths vs poverty	0.21	+0.42	0.17	0.010

Poverty is a **significant but modest** predictor: poorer states are more violent, but poverty explains only 14–17% of the variance. Violence is **uncorrelated with population size** (r = +0.02) — insecurity is not an artefact of large states.

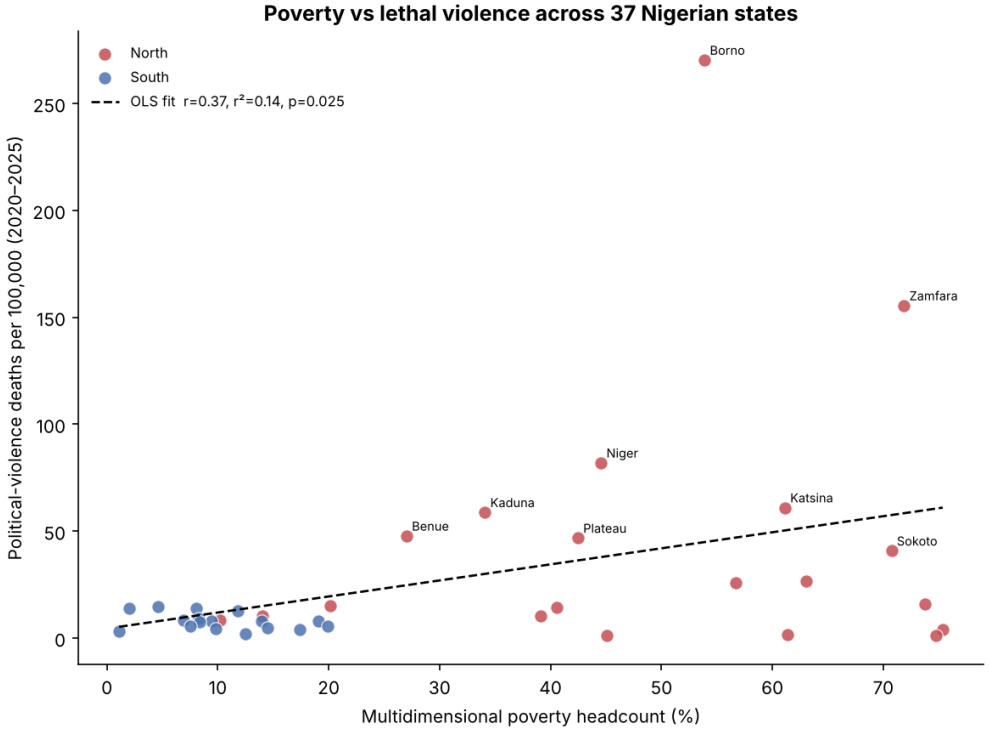


Figure 1. Poverty vs lethal violence, 37 states, with OLS fit. Northern states (red) cluster at high poverty and high violence.

2. Mapping the objective landscape

Choropleths on official HDX state boundaries. All share one pattern: a high-insecurity, high-poverty northern band against a low-risk southern belt.

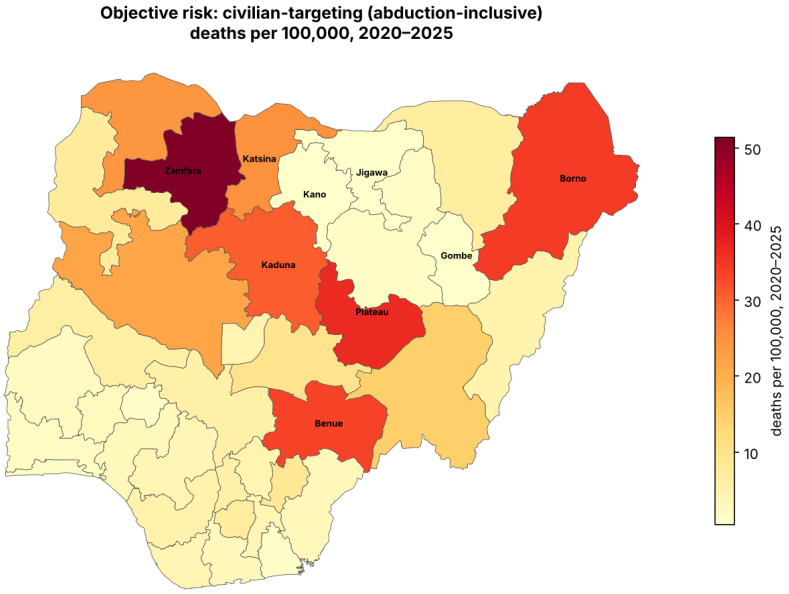


Figure 2. Objective kidnapping-proxy risk: civilian-targeting (abduction-inclusive) deaths per 100,000, 2020–2025.

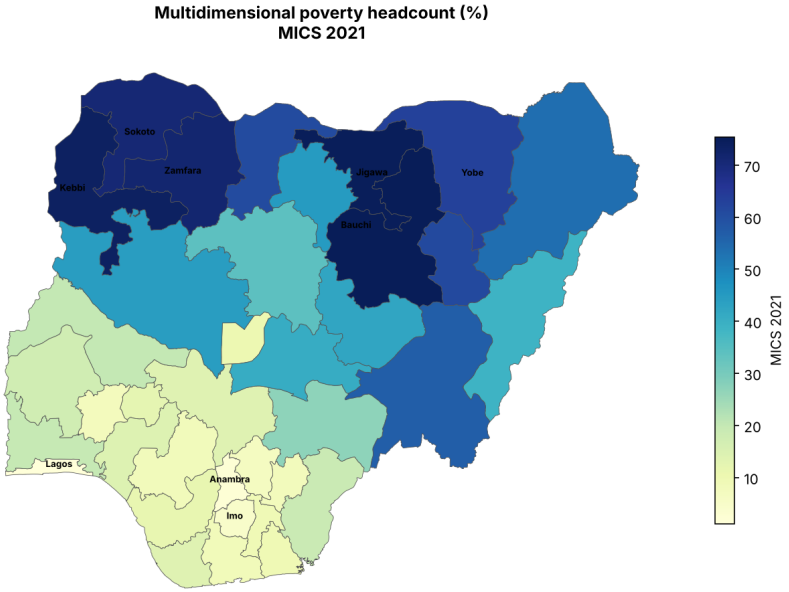


Figure 3. Multidimensional poverty headcount (%), MICS 2021.

3. Composite Insecurity–Vulnerability Index & typology

The Insecurity–Vulnerability Index (IVI) rescales 0.6·risk + 0.4·poverty (standardised) to 0–100. The ten highest-scoring states are all northern.

Rank	State	Zone	IVI	Typology
1	Zamfara	North West	100.0	High-risk / High-poverty
2	Borno	North East	99.8	High-risk / High-poverty
3	Sokoto	North West	58.5	High-risk / High-poverty
4	Katsina	North West	57.9	High-risk / High-poverty
5	Plateau	North Central	54.4	High-risk / High-poverty
6	Niger	North Central	51.0	High-risk / High-poverty
7	Kaduna	North West	48.3	High-risk / High-poverty
8	Benue	North Central	45.0	High-risk / High-poverty

Typology (risk × poverty, split at national medians): High-risk/High-poverty **14**; Lower-risk/Lower-poverty **13**; High-risk/Lower-poverty **5**; Lower-risk/High-poverty **5**. The two mixed cells break the simple "poverty → violence" story and are the analytically interesting states.

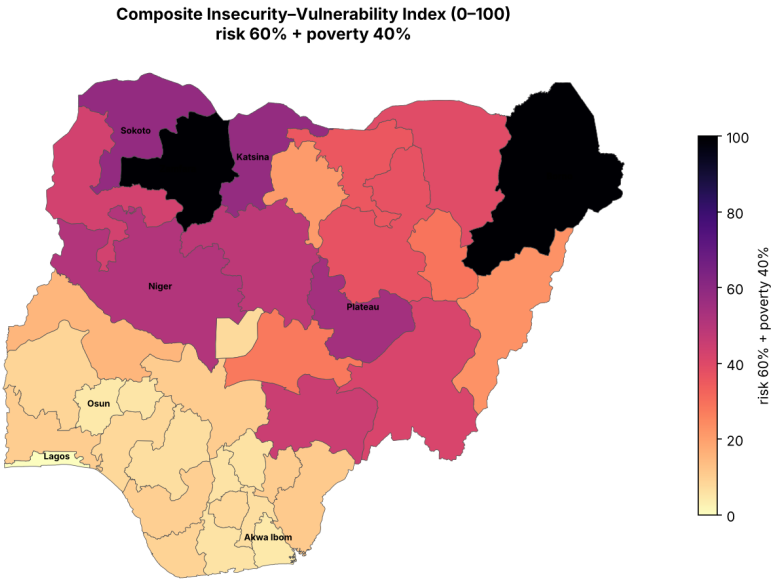


Figure 4. Composite Insecurity–Vulnerability Index (0–100).

4. Fear–risk mismatch: the geography-of-fear payoff

Mismatch = regional fear (z) – state objective risk (z). Positive = **fear exceeds local risk** (fear paradox); negative = **risk exceeds fear** (normalised danger).

Direction	States	Reading
Fear exceeds risk	Kano, Gombe, Jigawa, Bauchi, FCT	Low-violence northern states carrying 65% regional dread
Risk exceeds fear	Borno, Zamfara	Extreme violence under-registered even by high northern fear
Rising, under-feared	Ebonyi, Imo, Anambra	Southern violence outpacing still-moderate southern fear

Regional headline: the North's violent-death rate is **6×** the South's, yet its fear is only **1.16×** higher. The **South fears disproportionately to its objective risk** — consistent with kidnapping dread travelling via roads and media rather than local death counts. This decoupling is the study's central argument.

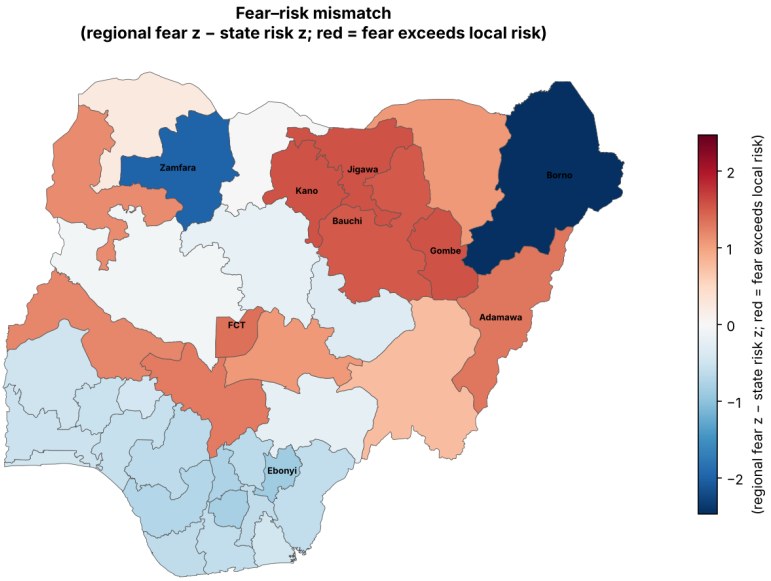


Figure 5. Fear–risk mismatch (red = fear exceeds local risk; blue = risk exceeds fear).

Caveat on the mismatch metric.

Because fear is constant within each region, the state-level mismatch largely re-expresses within-region risk variation. It validly illustrates the fear-paradox logic, but a genuine state-level fear–risk gap needs Afrobarometer microdata. Treat Figure 5 as indicative and the regional 6×-vs-1.16× comparison as robust.

5. What would sharpen every result

1. ACLED abduction export — replace the civilian-targeting proxy with true kidnapping counts; re-estimate the regression and rebuild the index on kidnapping specifically.
2. Afrobarometer R9/R10 microdata — state/zone fear estimates, turning Figure 5 into a real state-level fear–risk gap and enabling a perceived-vs-actual regression.

Sources & attribution

ACLED © Armed Conflict Location & Event Data Project (state-level aggregates only, per its Terms of Use). Afrobarometer Round 9 Nigeria, 2022. Multidimensional Poverty Index © OPHI, University of Oxford (MICS 2021). Boundaries: OCHA/HDX cod-ab-nga.

Population: NBS / National Population Commission. Kidnapping-fatality figures: Nigeria Watch (2024). Compiled 9 November 2026.